

GISMO Camera (Johannes Staguhn)

Sunday Expositions Series(#40)

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August 10, 2026

THE INVISIBLE COSMOS REWRITING THE NIGHT SKY

Let us begin with a profound yet humbling truth: our perception of reality is biologically imprisoned. When you stand under the canopy of a dark night sky—perhaps high in the Himalayas or away from the glaring lights of a sprawling metropolis like Pune or Mumbai—you might feel you are witnessing the universe in all its naked majesty. The sky is awash with glittering diamonds against a canvas of absolute black. But this is a biological illusion. The human eye is a spectacular evolutionary achievement, but as an astronomical instrument, its bandwidth is painfully narrow. We are tuned only to the energetic optical light that our own Sun happens to emit most abundantly.

To the universe, this 'visible' light is merely a single octave in a grand cosmic symphony that spans countless registers. The Goddard IRAM Superconducting 2-Millimeter Observer, or GISMO, is our attempt to build a mechanical ear capable of hearing the deepest, most resonant bass notes of this symphony. By learning to see the submillimetre continuum, we are not simply building a better telescope; we are fundamentally re-defining what it means for space to be 'dark'. In this chapter, we will strip away the optical illusion of the night sky, replacing the mathematics of thermal radiation and quantum detectors with the intuitive physics of heat, shadows, and the profound stillness of extreme cold.

Section 1.1: The Myth of the Dark Void - The Shadows That Shine

For millennia, stargazers looked up at the Milky Way and noticed great, winding rivers of pitch-black nothingness carving through the star fields. Even the great astronomers of the past thought these were literal 'holes in the heavens'—vast, empty voids where God simply forgot to place any stars.

To understand what these dark patches truly are, imagine standing in the streets of Mumbai during the peak of the monsoon. When you look up, the sky is a heavy, bruising charcoal grey, so dark that streetlights flicker on at midday. Why is it dark? Not because

the Sun has vanished, but because dense, moisture-laden clouds are standing between you and the solar glare. From above, viewed from an aeroplane, those same monsoon clouds are blindingly white, fiercely reflecting the sunlight.

The dark rifts in the Milky Way are exactly this: cosmic monsoon clouds. They are colossal, sprawling nebulae made of incredibly cold cosmic dust and gas. To our optical eyes, they appear as dark voids because the tiny, soot-like dust grains—composed of silicates and carbon—scatter and absorb the shorter wavelengths of visible starlight from the stars shining behind them.

Here is where GISMO completely shatters our standard intuition. By tuning its sensors to the submillimetre continuum—light waves that are about two millimetres long, much longer and more sluggish than optical light—GISMO does not attempt to look *past* or *through* these dark clouds. Instead, it looks directly *at* them.

You see, in physics, there is no such thing as absolute blackness as long as there is heat. Even in the depths of space, these dust clouds possess a faint, lingering warmth. And everything that has warmth must radiate light. The dust grains, hovering just a few degrees above absolute zero, are shivering. This microscopic thermal trembling generates long, slow waves of light. When we look through GISMO's eyes, the 'darkest' parts of the sky suddenly ignite. The voids vanish, replaced by blindingly bright, glowing filamentary webs of dust. We realise that the darkness of space was never an absence of cosmic structure; it was merely a failure of our biological vision.

The Takeaway: The darkness of space is merely a failure of human vision, not an absence of cosmic structure.

Section 1.2: Cosmic Night Vision - The Thermal Goggles of the Universe

To truly grasp how GISMO 'sees', we must step away from the concept of looking for light and begin to think about looking for heat.

Imagine you are standing deep in the dense forests of the Nilgiris at midnight. It is a moonless night, and the canopy overhead is thick. With your standard binoculars, you see absolutely nothing; the forest

is a monolithic wall of black. Now, you pull a pair of military-grade thermal infrared goggles over your eyes. Instantly, the invisible world reveals itself. The cold trees remain dark, but the warm body of a leopard resting on a branch suddenly glows with an intense, fiery brilliance against the cool background. You are no longer seeing the light bouncing off the leopard; you are seeing the light generated by the leopard's own internal body heat.

GISMO is the ultimate set of thermal goggles, but scaled for the sheer immensity of the cosmos. However, the universe is not a warm-blooded animal. To understand the scale of what GISMO looks for, consider a thought experiment involving a quintessential Indian experience: a boiling cup of cutting chai.

When the chaiwala pours the boiling tea, to a thermal camera, that cup is a blinding, white-hot beacon. As it sits on the counter, it cools. As its temperature drops, the physical properties of the light it emits change. The waves of light become longer, less energetic, stretching out. If you left that cup of tea to cool not just to room temperature, but out in the deepest, emptiest stretches of interstellar space, it would continue to cool down until it hovered just a tiny fraction of a degree above absolute zero—the theoretical limit where all atomic motion stops.

At this unimaginable chill, the tea would no longer emit infrared heat that standard goggles could see. Its light would stretch out so far it would become submillimetre radiation. GISMO is specifically designed to hunt for this exact, faint whisper of heat. Instead of looking for the searing, violent plasma of burning stars, it calmly scans the universe for the gentle, frigid thermal glow of interstellar dust.

The Takeaway: To see the hidden architecture of the universe, we must stop looking for the brightest objects and start listening for the faintest whispers of heat.

Section 1.3: The Macroscopic View - The Universe's Recycling Centres

Let us step back and look at the macroscopic ballet of the cosmos. Why does this cold dust exist in the first place?

Stars do not live forever. They are nuclear furnaces, spending billions of years crushing simple hydrogen and helium atoms together to forge heavier elements: carbon, oxygen, nitrogen, and silicon. But eventually, the fuel runs out. When a massive star dies, it does not do so quietly; it detonates in a cataclysmic supernova, violently shedding its heavy elemental cargo out into the immense, empty ocean of the interstellar medium.

Think of a bustling railway station like Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus (CSMT) in Mumbai. A train pulls in, and a massive, dense crowd of passengers erupts onto the platform, spreading out, dissipating into the city. But slowly, over time, the city's gravity pulls people back together—new groups form, queueing up for different trains, embarking on new journeys.

The universe operates on the same principle, over

eons. The 'ash' blown out by dying stars is swept up by cosmic gravity, drifting and clumping together over billions of years. This is the dust that GISMO detects. When GISMO maps these submillimetre clouds, it is not just taking a picture; it is acting as a cosmic census-taker, mapping the vast, interstellar recycling centres of the universe.

This leads us to a profound cosmological reflection. When we look at this glowing dust, we are peering into the womb of creation. Gravity forces these cold clouds to collapse inward. As they compress, they heat up, eventually sparking the ignition of brand-new stars, surrounded by swirling disks of leftover dust that will soon accrete into planets, oceans, and perhaps, eventually, beings capable of looking back at the sky. You are watching the literal scaffolding of existence. The carbon in your DNA, the iron in your blood, the silicon in the computer reading this—it all once floated in a frigid, glowing cloud exactly like the ones GISMO maps today.

The Takeaway: You are looking at the exact physical mechanism by which the cosmos recycles the dead to forge the living.

Section 1.4: Freezing to See - The Paradox of the Frozen Camera

We now arrive at a beautiful engineering paradox that sits at the heart of submillimetre physics. If you wish to capture the faintest echoes of cosmic heat, your camera cannot be warm.

Imagine you are trying to hear a child whispering a secret across a crowded, chaotic Delhi marketplace at Diwali. The sheer volume of firecrackers, shouting vendors, and honking horns creates a wall of acoustic noise that completely drowns out the whisper. The only way to hear the child is to silence the market entirely.

In physics, heat is motion. Heat is the chaotic, violent vibration of atoms. If the GISMO camera were operated at room temperature, the atoms comprising its own lenses, mirrors, and sensors would be vibrating with thermal energy. This internal vibration emits its own blinding submillimetre radiation. The camera would be hopelessly blinded by its own internal 'noise', exactly like trying to photograph a dim firefly while you are staring directly into the beam of a military searchlight.

To solve this, physicists must silence the atomic marketplace. GISMO is placed inside a cryostat, a hyper-advanced thermos flask, and cooled using liquid helium down to roughly 0.1 Kelvin. This is one-tenth of a degree above absolute zero. At this temperature, the camera becomes one of the coldest objects in the known universe—colder even than the deep space it is looking at.

But why 0.1 Kelvin precisely? This is where we cross into the magic of phase transitions and quantum mechanics. The sensors in GISMO rely on a phenomenon called superconductivity. Much like water freezing suddenly into ice, some metals, when cooled past a critical threshold, undergo a sudden phase transition. Their

electrons stop bouncing off the atomic lattice and pair up, flowing with absolutely zero electrical resistance. It is a state of profound quantum stillness.

The engineers hold GISMO's sensors delicately balanced right on the razor's edge of this transition—halfway between normal resistance and zero resistance. It is like balancing a boulder at the very precipice of a high cliff. When a single, sluggish, incredibly weak submillimetre photon from a distant galaxy finally ends its billion-year journey and strikes the sensor, it deposits a microscopic drop of heat. This tiny nudge is enough to push the material over the edge, abruptly destroying the superconductivity and causing a massive, easily measurable spike in electrical resistance.

We freeze the machine to a state of near-death, creating a silence so absolute that the arrival of a single particle of ancient light sounds like a thunderclap.

The Takeaway: To capture the faintest echoes of cosmic heat, the observer itself must become one of the coldest objects in the universe.

THE COLD ARCHITECTURE MATHEMATICS AND ASTROPHYSICS

We have journeyed through the macroscopic illusions of the night sky, discovering that the cosmic dark is, in truth, a glowing tapestry of creation. But to truly understand the Goddard IRAM Superconducting 2-Millimeter Observer (GISMO), we must now cross the threshold from passive stargazing into the rigorous, structural heart of astrophysics. Here, the universe is governed not merely by aesthetics, but by the relentless, elegant machinery of thermodynamics, quantum mechanics, and general relativity. In this chapter, we will strip away the symbolic mathematics and instead build a profound physical intuition for how light behaves over billions of years, how spacetime itself stretches, and how a meticulously engineered piece of cold metal can capture the faintest whispers of the cosmos.

Section 2.1: The Submillimetre Regime - Wien's Displacement and the Colour of Cold

Let us begin with a fundamental law of nature: everything in the universe glows.

To understand this, imagine walking through a rural village in Rajasthan at dusk and coming across a traditional *lohar*—an ironsmith—working at his forge. When a piece of iron sits in the cool evening air, it appears black. But as the smith plunges it into the coals, it begins to change. First, it emits a deep, dull red. As it gets hotter, the colour shifts to a bright orange, then to a searing yellow, and finally, if heated enough, to a blinding blue-white.

This everyday occurrence is a profound expression of thermodynamics. The temperature of an object is mathematically locked to the 'colour'—or wavelength—of the light it emits most intensely. The hotter the object, the more energetic and compressed its light waves become. Our Sun, burning at nearly six thousand

degrees Celsius on its surface, peaks in the energetic, tightly-packed wavelengths of visible yellow light.

But what happens when you go in the opposite direction? What happens to the 'colour' of an object when it is unimaginably cold?

Deep in interstellar space, the sprawling clouds of cosmic dust we discussed in the previous chapter sit at a staggering ten to thirty degrees above absolute zero. At these profound depths of cold, the dust still glows, but its light waves are lethargic, stretched out, and deeply relaxed. Instead of microscopic waves of visible light, the cold dust emits waves that are about a millimetre or two in length. We call this the submillimetre regime.

GISMO is precisely tuned to look at light waves that are exactly two millimetres long. This choice of 'colour' is not arbitrary; it is a stroke of astrophysical genius. If GISMO looked at slightly longer wavelengths, it would be utterly blinded by the cosmic microwave background—the fading, omnipresent flash of the Big Bang itself. If it looked at shorter wavelengths, it would see the blinding glare of warm local dust. By tuning exactly to two millimetres, GISMO threads a cosmic needle, giving us an unobstructed, perfectly clear view of the universe's coldest, most ancient primordial dust.

The Takeaway: Temperature and colour are mathematically locked together, allowing us to read the universe's thermometer simply by measuring the physical length of its light waves.

Section 2.2: Astrophysics of Dust - The Wombs of Ancient Galaxies

When we think of a star being born, we often imagine a brilliant, sudden ignition of light. The reality is far more violent, chaotic, and profoundly obscured. Star formation happens deep inside immensely thick, crushing envelopes of dust and gas. To optical telescopes like Hubble, these regions are impenetrable brick walls.

To grasp how astrophysicists bypass this wall, think of a massive Indian wedding *pandal* (a grand marquee) at night, made of thick, brightly coloured fabric. If you are standing outside, you cannot see the individual halogen bulbs hung inside. However, the thick cloth absorbs the intense, glaring light from the bulbs and softly re-emits it, glowing warmly from within. Even without seeing the bulbs directly, you can easily estimate how many lights are inside just by measuring the total brightness of the glowing tent.

In the cosmos, the dust clouds act exactly like the fabric of the *pandal*. When newborn stars violently ignite, they unleash a torrent of fierce, lethal ultraviolet radiation. The surrounding dust swallows this ultraviolet light entirely, preventing it from ever reaching Earth. But the dust cannot hold onto this energy forever. It heats up slightly and must release the energy back into space. It does so by 'downconverting' the fierce ultraviolet energy into a gentle, slow, submillimetre glow.

Here is the brilliant trick of modern astrophysics: by measuring the exact amount of submillimetre light pouring out of a distant galaxy, we are essentially counting the hidden, unborn stars inside it. GISMO mea-

asures this radiant flux and allows physicists to calculate the exact Star Formation Rate—the cosmic birth rate—of galaxies billions of light-years away, peering straight through the universe’s heaviest curtains.

The Takeaway: The dust that hides the birth of stars from our eyes is the very medium that broadcasts their existence to our instruments.

Section 2.3: The Redshift Paradox - The Negative K-Correction Loophole

Now we must introduce the mind-bending reality of an expanding universe, and a miraculous mathematical loophole that makes GISMO’s mission possible.

In everyday life, we are accustomed to the inverse-square law: the further away a light source is, the dimmer it appears. A streetlamp in Pune is bright when you stand beneath it, but a mere pinprick of light when seen from a distant hilltop. Under normal circumstances, galaxies from the dawn of time should be far too dim for us to ever see.

But the universe is not static. Spacetime itself is expanding. Imagine drawing a wavy line on a rubber band and then pulling the ends apart; the waves stretch out. Similarly, as light travels across the expanding cosmos over billions of years, its wavelength is physically stretched. A short, energetic wave emitted by a distant galaxy arrives at Earth as a long, lethargic wave. We call this ‘redshift’.

For standard optical telescopes, redshift is a curse. The visible light from early galaxies is stretched into the infrared, making them vanish from optical sight. But for GISMO, redshift is a miracle.

Early, aggressively star-forming galaxies emit the vast majority of their energy in the far-infrared spectrum. As these galaxies are pushed further and further away by the expansion of the universe, they should become impossibly dim. But simultaneously, their brilliant, blinding far-infrared light is stretched perfectly into GISMO’s two-millimetre viewing window.

This creates a spectacular paradox known as the negative K-correction. As the galaxy gets further away and dimmer, its peak emission slides right into the exact frequency where GISMO is most sensitive. The two effects perfectly cancel each other out. Astonishingly, a galaxy from the infant universe—so distant that its light has been travelling since long before the Earth even existed—will appear just as bright in GISMO’s camera as a similar galaxy located right in our cosmic neighbourhood.

The Takeaway: In the submillimetre spectrum, cosmic expansion magically cancels out cosmic dimming, giving us a free, unclouded window into the dawn of time.

Section 2.4: The Mathematical Thermometer - Transition Edge Sensors (TES)

We have spoken of catching this ancient, stretched light, but how do we physically trap a two-millimetre photon? The answer lies at the bleeding edge of quantum engineering: the Transition Edge Sensor.

To understand the sheer delicacy of this machine, imagine the precise moment water turns to ice. At exactly zero degrees Celsius, water is in a state of profound indecision, trembling between a free-flowing liquid and a rigid solid. Now, imagine a heavy, crowded Mumbai local train, packed to the absolute brim. It is perfectly stable, yet held at maximum capacity. If just one more person tries to board, the entire system loses its stability, and chaos ensues.

A Transition Edge Sensor operates on a similar precipice, using the quantum magic of superconductivity. At a fraction of a degree above absolute zero, certain metals lose all electrical resistance. Electrons, normally bouncing around chaotically, pair up in an elegant quantum dance and flow without any friction.

The physicists operating GISMO hold a tiny square of superconducting metal exactly on the ‘transition edge’—the microscopic thermal boundary where the metal is trapped halfway between normal resistance and zero resistance. It is an electrical circuit held in a state of exquisite, hyper-sensitive agony.

When a single, lethargic submillimetre photon—having travelled uninterrupted through the vacuum of space for ten billion years—finally strikes this sensor, it is absorbed. The photon perishes, depositing a microscopic, almost unimaginably small whisper of heat into the metal.

Because the metal is balanced right on the edge of a phase transition, this tiny ghost of a temperature bump is enough to shatter the quantum dance. The metal instantly ‘melts’ back into normal resistance. This sudden, violent change in the metal’s state creates a massive, easily measurable spike in the electrical current flowing through the circuit. We have taken the thermodynamic whisper of the ancient universe and translated it, flawlessly, into a loud, clear electrical heartbeat.

The Takeaway: By balancing an electrical circuit on the precipice of a quantum phase change, we force the universe to announce the arrival of a single particle of light.

THE QUANTUM FRONTIER INFORMATION, CIVILISATION, AND LIMITS

We have thus far explored the macroscopic tapestry of cosmic dust and the thermodynamic trickery required to observe it. Yet, the true majesty of the Goddard IRAM Superconducting 2-Millimeter Observer (GISMO) lies in its intimate relationship with the fundamental nature of reality. At the extreme edges of astrophysics, classical intuition shatters. When we look deep enough into spacetime, we are forced to confront the quantum mechanics of the detectors themselves, the statistical chaos of information theory, the thermodynamic inevitability of advanced civilisations, and the absolute physical limits of what can be known. Let us descend into the theoretical bedrock, where the oldest light in the universe meets the quantum frontier.

Section 3.1: Quantum Mechanics of Superconductivity - Breaking the Cooper Pairs

To truly understand how GISMO translates ancient light into human knowledge, we must abandon the idea of a camera as a simple bucket catching rain. We must enter the bizarre realm of BCS theory—named for Bardeen, Cooper, and Schrieffer—which governs the quantum mechanics of superconductivity.

In everyday physics, electrons abhor one another. Because they possess the same negative electrical charge, they fiercely repel each other, bouncing chaotically through the atomic lattice of a metal wire, generating friction and heat. This is standard electrical resistance. However, when the Transition Edge Sensors of GISMO are plunged to near absolute zero, the rules of reality change.

Imagine a massive, crowded festival floor during Navratri in Gujarat. Normally, the dancers move independently, keeping their distance to avoid collisions. But as the rhythm of the music reaches a perfect, hypnotic cadence, a remarkable synchronization occurs. A subtle vibration through the floorboards allows two dancers, separated by a vast crowd, to perfectly mirror each other's movements. They become a single, unified entity moving flawlessly through the chaos.

In a supercooled metal, the 'music' is the microscopic vibration of the atomic lattice itself. At near absolute zero, these lattice vibrations mediate a ghostly attraction between two electrons that would normally repel each other. They bind together into what physicists call a 'Cooper pair'. Bound by quantum entanglement, these pairs glide through the metal with absolute perfection, experiencing zero friction. This is superconductivity.

When a lethargic, two-millimetre photon from a galaxy at the dawn of time finally strikes this sensor, it carries just enough residual energy to disrupt the rhythm. The photon crashes into the lattice, severing the delicate quantum bond of a Cooper pair, splitting them back into normal, resistive electrons known as 'quasiparticles'.

GISMO does not merely measure a vague increase in temperature. Fundamentally, it is meticulously counting the microscopic fractures of quantum-entangled electron pairs. This process is bounded only by the fundamental fuzziness of Heisenberg's uncertainty principles and the absolute minimum energy required to break the bond.

The Takeaway: The macroscopic image of a distant galaxy is built pixel-by-pixel from the deliberate breaking of quantum entangled electron pairs.

Section 3.2: Information Theory in the Noise - The Poisson Whisper in the Cosmic Static

When we push our instruments to the absolute edge of their sensitivity, we encounter a profound philosophical problem: light is not a continuous river.

Because of quantum mechanics, light is granular; it arrives in discrete, indivisible packets called photons. If you stare at a bright streetlamp in Pune, countless

trillions of photons flood your eye every microsecond, creating the illusion of a smooth, steady beam. But when GISMO stares into the deepest voids of space, waiting for photons that have travelled for ten billion years, it does not receive a steady beam. It receives a trickle.

Imagine sitting on the veranda of an old Maharashtrian wada just as the monsoon begins. The rain does not start as a continuous roar. First, a single heavy drop strikes the tin roof. *Tap*. Silence. Then another. *Tap*. Then two close together. *Tap-tap*.

This arrival of individual droplets is fundamentally random, governed by a statistical concept known as a Poisson distribution. In astrophysics, we call this 'photon noise'. The sheer randomness of quantum mechanics means that the photons from a distant galaxy do not arrive evenly spaced; they drizzle onto the detector in a chaotic, unpredictable static.

At the limits of our vision, observing the universe stops being an exercise in photography and becomes a pure exercise in Information Theory. The theoretical physicist must write breathtakingly complex mathematical algorithms to listen to the random drumming on the roof and confidently state, 'There, hidden within the random chaos of the drizzle, is the steady, faint heartbeat of a newborn galaxy.'

The Takeaway: At the edge of our vision, the universe stops looking like a photograph and starts looking like a chaotic statistical probability distribution.

Section 3.3: Civilisation Detectability - The Thermodynamics of Megastructures

Let us entertain a philosophically thrilling scenario. If we are looking for the faintest whispers of heat in the cosmos, could GISMO detect an advanced extraterrestrial civilisation?

According to the unyielding laws of thermodynamics, no engine, no machine, and no biological process is perfectly efficient. Every act of performing 'work' invariably produces waste heat. An advanced alien species, perhaps a Kardashev Type II civilisation, might possess the engineering prowess to construct a Dyson Sphere—a colossal shell of solar panels encompassing their entire home star to harness its complete energy output.

From an optical perspective, the star would vanish; the civilisation would have walled it off. But they cannot cheat thermodynamics. Just like an enormous, traditional clay *tandoor* oven trapping a raging fire inside, the exterior wall of the Dyson Sphere must inevitably warm up. It must radiate the civilisation's unimaginable waste heat out into the void to prevent the structure from melting.

Theoretical models of astrophysics and thermodynamics converge to predict that this colossal sphere of waste heat would peak perfectly in the mid-to-far infrared and submillimetre continuum. Thus, GISMO's ability to map anomalous patches of submillimetre dust emission provides a devastatingly rigorous framework for SETI (the Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence). We do not need to wait for them to intentionally broad-

cast a radio greeting. We merely have to look for their industrial exhaust.

The Takeaway: Advanced extraterrestrial civilisations cannot hide from the laws of thermodynamics; their waste heat will invariably glow in the submillimetre dark.

Section 3.4: The Unsolved Frontier - The Confusion Limit and the Edge of Reality

We must conclude with a sobering reality: even if we perfect our quantum sensors and master the statistics of photon noise, we are hurtling towards an absolute physical boundary.

Light, behaving as a wave, bends and diffracts when it enters a telescope. Because GISMO observes light at relatively long wavelengths (two millimetres), its resulting image is inherently slightly blurry. This physical diffraction limit means that a single 'pixel' in GISMO's vision covers a surprisingly large patch of the sky.

Imagine standing on a bustling road like Laxmi Road in Pune during the Diwali festival. Up close, you can easily distinguish individual faces and the separate flames of clay *diyas*. But as you look further and further down the long, straight road, the distant lights begin to swell and merge. Eventually, your eyes cannot separate the individual lamps. The end of the street appears as a solid, undifferentiated wall of golden glare.

In astrophysics, this is known as the 'confusion limit'. The infant universe was phenomenally fertile, birthing submillimetre-bright galaxies by the billions. If GISMO stares deeply enough into the cosmos, there are simply so many of these ancient galaxies that several of them overlap within a single pixel of the camera's sensor.

At this profound physical boundary, building a more sensitive detector does not help. The individual galaxies blur into an impenetrable, glowing fog of primordial origins. We find ourselves staring at the cosmological horizon, looking back so far in time that we approach the Big Bang itself—a singularity where the smooth fabric of general relativity breaks down, and asking what happened 'before time' becomes as geometrically meaningless as asking what lies north of the North Pole.

The Takeaway: We are approaching the absolute physical limit of observation, where the sheer abundance of the universe blurs into a continuous wall of primordial light.